

THE TITAN *in the* SKINNER BOX

Abyssal Autarky, Parasitic Sovereignty, and Saturn's Verdict in BioShock

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Abstract

This thesis argues that *BioShock* (Irrational Games, as 2K Boston, with 2K Australia, 2007; creative direction by Ken Levine) is not, as its reception has largely assumed, a refutation of Objectivism conducted by narrative means. It is a three-sided adjudication of a single question: to whom does a human being belong? Three claimants contest that title across the game's fiction and its procedural architecture. Ownership, the Lockean and Randian claim of the self-proprietor, is embodied by Andrew Ryan and extended at its limit into the right to destroy what one owns. Command, the behaviorist claim of the conditioner, is embodied by Frank Fontaine and his scientists and condensed in the trigger formula*would you kindly*. Care, the claim of the one who shapes and tends a life, is embodied by Brigid Tenenbaum and, finally, by the protagonist himself.

The thesis draws on the historical controversy between Ayn Rand and B. F. Skinner, on Michel Serres's theory of the parasite, and on a mythic complex organized around Saturn: devouring father, exiled founder of a hidden golden age, and, in Hyginus's fable of Cura, the judge who awards the living human to Care. From these it advances four claims. First, Rapture realizes a political ontology here termed *abyssal autarky*: the fantasy of a sovereign subject constituted as a pressure hull, sealed against an exterior it must perpetually resist. Second, this autarky is constitutively parasitic, deriving its vitality from extracted life it disavows. Third, the game's ludic form is structurally behaviorist, so that its celebrated ludonarrative dissonance is better understood as a mimesis of ideology: the formal reproduction of the gap between a subject's self-description as free and its actual conditioning. Fourth, the game's only coherent emancipation, available solely in its restorative ending and solely as non-interactive spectacle, enacts *Saturn's verdict*: the renunciation of proprietary and commanding claims in favour of a finite, elective, non-proprietary care. This is an ethic the game can depict but, being a behaviorist machine, cannot permit to be played. The argument is situated within the comparative horizons of Hesiodic, Platonic, biblical, Miltonic, and Goethean myth, and of the horror lineage running from Shelley and Poe through Wells and Lovecraft.

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1 Introduction

The Pressure Hull of the Self

1.1 Problem and Corpus

BioShock opens with a descent, and every element of that descent is a thesis in miniature. A transatlantic flight in 1960 ends in the sea. A lone survivor swims to a lighthouse whose Art Deco interior is dominated by the bust of a founder and a banner that abolishes gods and kings in favour of Man alone. A bathysphere carries him downward while a projected film delivers the founder's credo, and the screen lifts to disclose a city on the ocean floor.

The lighthouse, an instrument for warding vessels away from danger, here draws them toward it. The tower, which in the Babel narrative reaches upward toward the divine, here extends downward and away from it. The city is first encountered not as a place but as a projection, a spectacle in Guy Debord's sense (1967), in which social relations are mediated by images. And the film's founding question, couched in the biblical idiom of the sweating brow, asks whether a man may keep what his labour produces. In doing so it transvalues the Adamic curse of Genesis 3:19, in which toil is the punishment of the Fall, into a Lockean title deed, in which toil is the origin of property. Rapture is presented from its first frame as a theological inversion, a mediated spectacle, and a juridical claim.

This study takes that overdetermination as its object. Its corpus is the original *BioShock*, approached as a composite text: level architecture; environmental inscription in posters, signage, and advertising; the recovered audio diaries through which the city's history is reconstructed; scripted sequences; the progression and economy systems; and the branching endings. The sequels,

BioShock 2 (2K Marin, 2010), *BioShock Infinite* (Irrational Games, 2013), and the *Burial at Sea* episodes (2013–14), are invoked only where they illuminate the original's logic.

1.2 State of the Question

Critical response has consolidated around three positions. The first, philosophical, reads the game as a critique of Ayn Rand's Objectivism. It notes the transparent onomastic correspondences (Andrew Ryan and Ayn Rand; Atlas and *Atlas Shrugged*; Fontaine and *The Fountainhead*) and the biographical parallel between an émigré founder and an émigré novelist, each a refugee from Bolshevik Russia turned prophet of individualism; the essays collected in Luke Cuddy's *BioShock and Philosophy* (2015) are representative. The second, ludological, follows Clint Hocking's 2007 diagnosis of ludonarrative dissonance: the charge that the game's rules reward the self-interest its narrative condemns, while its plot compels an obedience its rules pretend is optional. The third, formalist, celebrates the trigger-phrase revelation as a reflexive exposure of the player's obedience to the imperatives by which games habitually proceed.

Each position is correct within its frame and incomplete outside it. The philosophical reading treats Objectivism as the game's sole interlocutor, overlooking the behaviorist tradition against which Rand herself defined her position. The ludological reading treats dissonance as a defect rather than a representational achievement. The formalist reading treats the revelation as a terminus rather than as the opening of a problem that the remainder of the game attempts, and largely fails, to solve within its own medium.

1.3 Argument

The argument proceeds from a governing image. Rapture is a city whose every interior exists only by virtue of a pressure differential: a sealed volume maintained against an ocean that presses inward at every seam. The game's ubiquitous leaks, cracked glass, and flooded corridors are therefore not set dressing but the material index of its political ontology. This study names that ontology *abyssal autarky*: the conception of the sovereign subject, individual or civic, as a pressure hull. Such a subject is a bounded interior whose freedom is defined as the successful exclusion of an exterior medium (the social, the dependent, the unchosen, the other), and whose existence consequently requires perpetual and finally unsustainable resistance.

Goethe imagined such a polity in the last act of *Faust, Part Two* (1832): a free people on land reclaimed from the sea, deserving freedom only by reconquering it daily against the encroaching flood. Marshall Berman (1982) read

the scene as the tragedy of the developer, the modernizer whose project requires the destruction of whatever stands in its way. Rapture is that Faustian polity relocated beneath the waterline, and its fate repeats Goethe's irony: the blinded developer hears in the sound of spades the construction of his utopia, when it is in fact the digging of his grave.

Rapture is that Faustian polity relocated beneath the waterline.

Against this image the thesis sets a juridical question drawn from a Latin fable. In Hyginus's *Fabulae* (220), Care (Cura), crossing a river, shapes a figure from clay; Jupiter grants it spirit; Earth (Tellus) claims it as made of her substance. The disputants appoint Saturn as judge. He rules that at death Jupiter shall receive the spirit and Earth the body, but that Care shall possess the creature for as long as it lives; it shall be called *homo*, because it was made from *humus*. Heidegger cites the fable in *Being and Time* (1927, §42) as pre-philosophical testimony that the being of the human is care, noting Konrad Burdach's demonstration (1923) that Goethe drew on a version of it, transmitted through Herder, for the figure of Care who blinds Faust.

BioShock, it will be argued, restages this trial. Ryan advances Earth's claim: the human as property in its own person and body. Fontaine advances Jupiter's: the human as animated, and therefore owned, by the word that moves it. Tenenbaum advances Care's. The player, whose aggregate choices determine which ending the game computes, occupies the seat of Saturn, a figure who in Greek myth is also Kronos, the father who consumes his children to forestall succession. The game's central ethical binary is thereby reinterpreted as a choice between two Saturns: the devourer and the judge.

1.4 Method and Structure

The study combines intellectual history, comparative mythography, the theory of horror, and the procedural criticism developed by Espen Aarseth and Ian Bogost. Its premise is that in a ludic artifact philosophy is enacted at the level of rule as well as represented at the level of narrative. Chapter 2 reconstructs the Objectivist substrate and its Lockean and Smithian ancestry, culminating in the right to destroy. Chapter 3 reconstructs the behaviorist counter-substrate, situating the trigger phrase within the Rand–Skinner controversy and the Cold War discourse of brainwashing. Chapter 4 analyzes Rapture's biopolitics through the history of eugenics and the theory of the parasite. Chapter 5

maps the game's mythic architecture, and Chapter 6 situates Rapture within the genealogy of maritime and biological horror. Chapter 7 develops a theory of the game's ludic form as behaviorist apparatus. Chapter 8 presents the synthetic thesis, and Chapter 9 considers afterlives and limits.

The Objectivist Substrate

Property, Production, and the Right to Destroy

2.1 Ryan and Rand: Correspondence and Divergence

The correspondences between Andrew Ryan and Ayn Rand are deliberate and layered. Rand, born Alisa Rosenbaum in Saint Petersburg in 1905, emigrated to the United States in 1926 and spent her career elaborating Objectivism: metaphysical realism, reason as the sole means of knowledge, an ethics of rational self-interest, and a politics of laissez-faire capitalism grounded in the prohibition of initiated force. Ryan, a fictional refugee from the same revolution, carries her doctrine from the page into masonry. Rapture is legible as Galt's Gulch, the hidden valley of *Atlas Shrugged* (1957) in which the productive withdraw from a world they regard as parasitic, relocated from the Rockies to the abyss. Ryan's self-mythology as a builder echoes Howard Roark, the architect-hero of *The Fountainhead* (1943).

Two features of the fictional chronology sharpen the correspondence. Construction of Rapture begins in 1946, eleven years before *Atlas Shrugged* appeared, so that the city functions as a prolepsis: the novel's utopia built before the novel was written. The date also falls within months of the founding of the Mont Pèlerin Society in April 1947, at which Friedrich Hayek convened a small company of liberal economists on a Swiss mountain to defend market order against the postwar consensus. The postwar moment produced actual as well as fictional retreats, in which liberty was to be preserved by withdrawal to an elevated or submerged refuge.

The divergences are equally instructive. Rand repudiated the libertarian label and grounded her politics in an ethics of reason rather than in market ef-

ficiency. Ryan speaks most often in the idiom of the market's providential self-regulation, figured in his recurrent image of a great chain of industry moving as if guided by an invisible hand. The image fuses two genealogies. One is Adam Smith's invisible hand, which in *The Theory of Moral Sentiments* (1759) and *The Wealth of Nations* (1776) names the unintended social benefits of self-regarding action. The other is the medieval great chain of being reconstructed by Arthur Lovejoy (1936), the plenitudinous hierarchy linking every creature to God.

Ryan's chain is the *scala naturae* secularized: the theological hierarchy of being transposed into an economic hierarchy of productivity, with the producer at its summit and the parasite, Ryan's favoured term of abuse, at its base. The substance on which Rapture's economy finally depends is called ADAM. Whatever its intended reference, the name sounds both the first man of Genesis and the first theorist of the market, and the text never forecloses the double resonance.

2.2 Labour, Title, and the Body as Property

The juridical foundation of Ryan's polity is the chapter on property in Locke's *Second Treatise of Government* (1689): each person has a property in his own person, and whatever he removes from the common state of nature and mixes with his labour becomes his. Ryan's founding question compresses Locke's argument into a single interrogative, and the game's subsequent history tests both its premises.

Self-ownership is tested by the genetic economy, which makes the person purchasable, alterable, and saleable. Once the body can be improved by acquisition, the property one has in one's person becomes indistinguishable from the property one has in commodities. Labour as title is tested by the provenance of Rapture's wealth, which derives not from labour mixed with nature but from the extraction of a substance produced by an organism living within dependent hosts. The labour theory of property is undone by the discovery that the city's most valuable property is not made but taken.

The Lockean proviso, that appropriation is legitimate only where enough and as good is left in common for others, is visibly violated in Arcadia, the engineered forest that oxygenates the city and whose gates are, tellingly, metered. Air, the paradigmatic commons, becomes a ticketed amenity. The enclosure of the atmosphere repeats in miniature the history Marx called primitive accumulation (*Capital*, 1867), in which the conversion of common resources into private property precedes the market it is afterward said to presuppose.

2.3 Abusus: The Right to Destroy

Roman law decomposed full ownership into *usus* (the right to use), *fructus* (the right to the fruits), and *abusus* (the right to consume, alienate, or destroy). Ryan's career is a progressive purification of the third term. The game's lore records that when the state proposed to convert a forest he owned into a public park, he burned it rather than surrender it. In Arcadia he poisons the trees on which his own city's air depends rather than let them sustain his enemies. Facing defeat, he arms the city's self-destruct mechanism; in his final scene, he commands his own death.

The pattern is consistent and, within its own logic, rigorous: the proof of ownership is the capacity to annihilate what one owns, and the purest proof is annihilation in preference to alienation.*Abusus* is revealed as the hidden summit of the proprietary ethic, the point at which self-ownership converges with self-destruction. This convergence, Chapter 8 will argue, defines Earth's claim in Saturn's trial: the claim to the body as matter of which one may dispose entirely.

The proof of ownership is the capacity to annihilate what one owns.

2.4 Sovereignty and Exception

A polity founded on the abolition of the sovereign must eventually decide what to do when its foundations are threatened, and Rapture's crisis exposes the decision it cannot avoid. Carl Schmitt's *Political Theology* (1922) defines the sovereign as the one who decides on the exception. Ryan's response to insurgency shows that the anarcho-capitalist utopia contained a sovereign all along, latent until the exception summoned him: he prohibits contact with the surface, escalates the repression of smugglers and dissidents, and, most damningly, seizes Fontaine Futuristics after Fontaine's apparent death. The nationalization of a private enterprise by the prophet of private enterprise is the game's most economical refutation of Ryan's self-understanding. The market order he believed self-founding rests on a decision that is not itself a market transaction.

Walter Benjamin's *Origin of the German Trauerspiel* (1928), written in partial dialogue with Schmitt, gives a more exact portrait of what Ryan becomes. Benjamin's baroque sovereign is at once tyrant and martyr, incapable of the clean decision Schmitt ascribes to him, presiding over a history experienced as

ruin. Ryan traverses precisely this oscillation: the tyrant of the martial-law period yields to the martyr of the final scene, who stages his death as a demonstration of freedom. The city he leaves is a Trauerspiel landscape, a petrified history of decay in which, on Benjamin's account, ruin is the form allegory takes in the world of things.

2.5 Hegel, Nietzsche, and the Chooser's Dictum

Ryan's final dictum, that the free man chooses where the slave obeys, is usually read as an Objectivist maxim, but its dramatic function is Hegelian. In the dialectic of lordship and bondage in the *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807), made central to twentieth-century thought by Alexandre Kojève's lectures (1933–39), the master's freedom depends on recognition from a consciousness he has reduced to an instrument, and therefore cannot be secured. It is the bondsman, formed through labour and fear, who attains self-consciousness.

Ryan's death scene enacts the paradox with diagrammatic precision. To demonstrate that he chooses, Ryan must speak the phrase that compels his son, so that his supreme act of sovereign choice is executed through the body of a slave. The master can certify his freedom only through the bondsman's unfree obedience; mastery consumes itself in the act of self-assertion.

The dictum also inverts Nietzsche's typology in *On the Genealogy of Morality* (1887). For Nietzsche, master morality creates values from affirmative self-relation, while slave morality is reactive, born of ressentiment and organized by a priestly caste that directs the resentment of the weak. Ryan imagines himself a value-creating master. Fontaine, in the guise of Atlas, plays the ascetic priest, mobilizing the resentment of the city's dispossessed and redirecting it toward his own ends. That the priest proves to be a confidence man is the game's sardonic gloss on Nietzsche: in a polity in which everything has been commodified, ressentiment too becomes a market to be cornered.

3 The Behaviorist Counter-Substrate

Conditioning, Command, and the Rand–Skinner Controversy

3.1 Two Utopias, 1946–1948

The fictional founding of Rapture falls within two years of the publication of B. F. Skinner's *Walden Two* (1948), a novel describing a planned community in which conduct is shaped by positive reinforcement rather than coercion, and in which the question of freedom is meant to become obsolete. The two utopias are exact antitheses: Rapture is founded on the sovereignty of volition,*Walden Two* on its dissolution into contingencies of reinforcement. The game's deepest structural move is to show that Rapture becomes*Walden Two* without noticing, and that the transition requires no change of doctrine, only the extension of the market to the human organism.

The antithesis was not merely notional. When Skinner published*Beyond Freedom and Dignity* (1971), arguing that autonomous man was a pre-scientific fiction obstructing the design of a better culture, Rand answered with one of the most vehement polemics of her career, "The Stimulus and the Response" (1972), later collected in *Philosophy: Who Needs It* (1982). For Rand, volitional consciousness, the capacity to choose to focus one's mind, was the irreducible foundation of ethics, and its denial the root of tyranny.

This controversy is the hinge of the game's philosophical design. Ryan speaks Rand's side of it; Fontaine and his scientist Yi Suchong enact Skinner's. The revelation in Ryan's office is the moment at which the game declares, against its own founder, that the behaviorist was right about the protagonist and, Chapter 7 will argue, about the player.

3.2 Conditioning as Infrastructure

Rapture's commerce operates on the logic of the operant chamber. Ivan Pavlov's work on conditioned reflexes, John B. Watson's behaviorist manifesto (1913), and Skinner's analysis of reinforcement schedules established that behaviour can be reliably shaped by the contingent delivery of reward, and that intermittent, variable reinforcement produces the most persistent responding. The city is saturated with the apparatus of this science. Vending machines with jingles and anthropomorphic voices dispense ammunition, medicine, and genetic modification. Advertising on every wall promises self-transcendence through purchase. And ADAM, the substance that rewrites the body, is addictive, so that each acquisition both satisfies and intensifies the need for the next. Even the slogan of collective emancipation is absorbed: the weapon-upgrade stations bear the name Power to the People, a phrase of the radical left converted into a brand.

The Splicer, Rapture's degenerate citizen, is the terminal product of this regime: *homo economicus* completed, a consumer in whom desire has been wholly reorganized around the next increment of a commodity, and whose body has become the ledger of past purchases. Aldous Huxley's *Brave New World* (1932) had imagined a social order stabilized by neo-Pavlovian conditioning and pharmacological reward. Rapture reaches the same terminus by the opposite route, arriving at total conditioning not through a planning state but through its abolition.

3.3 The Password and the Hail

The trigger phrase belongs to a specific Cold War imaginary. The journalist Edward Hunter popularized the term brainwashing in 1950; Richard Condon's *The Manchurian Candidate* (1959) imagined a soldier conditioned to kill on presentation of a playing card; and the Central Intelligence Agency's MKUltra program (1953–73) pursued techniques of behavioural control through pharmacology, hypnosis, and sensory manipulation. Jack, the protagonist, is a Manchurian candidate engineered in Rapture's laboratories. He is the unacknowledged son of Andrew Ryan, acquired before birth by Fontaine, artificially aged, furnished with counterfeit memories of a surface childhood, and conditioned by Suchong to obey any instruction prefaced by the phrase. His wrists bear tattoos of chains, visible in the first-person frame throughout: the most legible emblem of bondage, displayed in plain sight to a player with no reason to read it.

Three theoretical frames clarify what the phrase does. Louis Althusser's account of interpellation (1970) holds that ideology constitutes subjects by hailing

them: the individual who turns in response to the call becomes the subject the call presupposed. The trigger phrase is interpellation stripped of ideological disguise, a hail that produces not a subject who recognizes himself but a body that moves.

Gilles Deleuze's "Postscript on the Societies of Control" (1990) distinguishes disciplinary societies, regulated by watchwords, from control societies, regulated by codes and passwords that grant or deny access, in which the individual becomes a *dividual*, a divisible bundle of data. The phrase is a password in the strict sense, an access code to a motor system. The game's genetic locks, which yield to Ryan's genotype and therefore to his son, extend the logic to identity itself, which becomes a credential. The plasmid interface, through which the protagonist swaps abilities in and out of a fixed number of slots, renders the self as modular inventory: the dividual made playable.

The phrase also has a grammatical form that matters. It is a formula of politeness, the conventional shape of a request that may be declined. In 1947, a year after Rapture's founding, the Nuremberg Code made the voluntary consent of the human subject the first principle of legitimate experimentation. The trigger phrase is the form of consent emptied of its substance, the syntax of a request welded to the force of a command. Rapture is, among other things, the jurisdiction constituted by the absence of the Nuremberg principle, and its master-signifier is a counterfeit of the very question that principle requires.

The trigger phrase is the form of consent emptied of its substance.

3.4 The Entrepreneur of the Self

Michel Foucault's lectures*The Birth of Biopolitics* (1978–79) identified in American neoliberalism, and particularly in Gary Becker's theory of human capital, a new figure of the subject: the entrepreneur of himself, who treats his capacities as capital and his life as an enterprise. Rapture literalizes this figure with a specificity that anticipates the theory's later popularization. The genetic marketplace converts human capital from metaphor into biochemistry: one invests in one's own genome, and the return is measured in power. The Splicer's disfigurement is the visible balance sheet of the enterprise.

The game thereby exposes a contradiction internal to the neoliberal subject. The entrepreneur of the self is at once the most autonomous of agents, sovereign over his own development, and the most thoroughly conditioned,

since the value of every investment is set by incentives he does not author. Rand's volitional chooser and Skinner's reinforced organism converge in this figure, and Rapture's ruin is the record of their convergence.

4 Biopolitics of the Deep

Eugenics, Human Capital, and Parasitic Sovereignty

4.1 Eugenics in Market Form

Francis Galton coined the term eugenics in *Inquiries into Human Faculty* (1883), extending the arguments of *Hereditary Genius* (1869) into a program for improving the human stock through selective breeding. The program's lineage runs backward to the regulated breeding of guardians in Book V of Plato's *Republic*, and forward through the sterilization statutes of the early twentieth century to the racial hygiene of the Third Reich. Rapture inherits this lineage but alters its institutional form. Classical eugenics was a project of the state, administered through law and coercion; Rapture's is a project of the market, administered through price and choice.

The genetic marketplace thus anticipates what Nicholas Agar (2004) would defend as liberal eugenics: enhancement chosen by individuals rather than imposed by governments. The game's verdict on the distinction is unsparing. Its consumer eugenics produces degeneration rather than improvement, a population whose purchased perfections metastasize into deformity. And it requires, as the condition of its supply, exactly the coercion of the vulnerable that liberal eugenics claims to have left behind.

Jürgen Habermas's objection in *The Future of Human Nature* (2001) supplies the precise terms of the critique. Habermas argues that a person whose characteristics have been intentionally designed by another may be unable to regard herself as the undivided author of her own life, and that the asymmetry between designer and designed disturbs the symmetry of recognition on which moral equality depends. Jack is the limiting case of the argument: a person

whose genome, maturation, memories, and motor obedience have all been authored by others, and whose discovery of that fact is the game's central crisis.

4.2 The Clinic and the Studio: Steinman and Cohen

Two districts dramatize the aestheticization of the newly plastic body. In the Medical Pavilion, the surgeon J. S. Steinman, intoxicated by the possibility of reshaping flesh without limit, pursues an ideal of beauty his patients cannot survive. He is an inverted Pygmalion: where Ovid's sculptor (*Metamorphoses* X) loves a statue into life, Steinman converts living persons into failed statuary.

In Fort Frolic, the artist Sander Cohen commissions the protagonist to kill his former disciples and photograph the results, which he assembles into a composite artwork. Cohen's project realizes with unsettling literalness the warning that closes Walter Benjamin's essay on the work of art in the age of its technological reproducibility (1935–36): that a humanity sufficiently alienated from itself can experience its own destruction as aesthetic pleasure, and that the aestheticization of politics culminates in war. Cohen's camera is Benjamin's apparatus of reproduction pressed into the service of the death it records.

The masquerade imagery that pervades the city recalls Poe's "The Masque of the Red Death" (1842), in which a prince walls his court away from a plague that is already within the walls. Many of Rapture's inhabitants still wear the masks of the New Year's Eve celebration of 1958 on which its civil war began.

4.3 The Parasite

The deepest biopolitical structure of the game is disclosed by Michel Serres's *The Parasite* (1980). Serres argues that the parasitic relation is not an aberration in systems but their elementary form. The relation means taking without giving in return and also, in the French sense of *parasite* as static, interference within a channel. Every system has its parasite, every parasite has its parasite, and order emerges from the cascade of these asymmetric relations.

Ryan's rhetoric divides the world into producers and parasites and builds a city to exclude the latter. The economy of that city, however, rests entirely on ADAM, a substance produced by a marine organism that lives within a host. The excluded category returns as the literal foundation: the producers' city is a parasite's city.

The producers' city is a parasite's city.

The cascade Serres describes can be traced with diagrammatic clarity. The organism draws its sustenance from its host. The host, one of the conditioned children called Little Sisters, gathers ADAM from the city's dead. Each child is guarded by a Protector, one of the armoured, diving-suited figures the fiction calls Big Daddies, who is himself chemically bound to his charge. The Splicers prey upon the pair, and the protagonist, in order to advance, preys upon all of them. Each term lives off the next, and the player occupies the final position: the parasite of parasites. Rapture's founding opposition between producers and parasites is not refuted by argument. It is dissolved by an ecology in which no position lies outside the parasitic chain.

4.4 Bare Life and the Problem of the Child

Giorgio Agamben's *Homo Sacer* (1995) describes bare life as life exposed to a sovereign power that may end it without either sacrifice or crime, and identifies the camp as the space in which the exception becomes the rule. The Little Sisters occupy this position in Rapture's order. Drawn from orphanages and poorhouses under Fontaine's control, they are legally nobody's children and economically everybody's resource.

The scientist whose research first made them hosts, Brigid Tenenbaum, is herself a survivor of the Nazi camp system, whose expertise was coerced into its medical apparatus. This is the game's most deliberate historical rhyme. The camp's logic, which she survived, is reconstituted in the free city; and her later turn from author of that logic to its undoer is the moral axis on which the game's resolution turns.

The central design decision follows from this position. Having overcome a Protector, the player must choose between extracting the organism from its host lethally, for the larger yield of ADAM, and removing it restoratively, freeing the child, for a smaller one. The decision has generated more commentary than any other element of the game, and its full analysis is reserved for Chapters 7 and 8. Here it suffices to note its biopolitical form: the choice is posed as a transaction, its terms are priced, and its moral content is staged entirely within the economy it is meant to judge.

Mythic Architecture

Titans, Exiles, and Counterfeit Calls

5.1 The Titanic Register

Rapture's Art Deco idiom quotes, with evident deliberation, the Manhattan of Rockefeller Center, whose sunken plaza is presided over by Paul Manship's gilded *Prometheus* (1934) and whose Fifth Avenue courtyard holds the bronze *Atlas* of Lee Lawrie and Rene Chambellan (1937). The two Titans were the iconographic guardians of interwar American capital, figures of heroic labour and stolen fire installed at the heart of a speculative real-estate venture. *BioShock* submerges this iconography and lets it decay. Its geography names the myths outright: the power plant at the city's heart is Hephaestus, the laboratory where conditioned life is manufactured is Point Prometheus, and the revolutionary who speaks to the protagonist by radio calls himself Atlas.

Hesiod's *Theogony* supplies the grammar. Prometheus steals fire for humanity and is punished; Atlas, a Titan who fought against the Olympians, is condemned to bear the sky. Hephaestus, the lame craftsman god, fashions the first woman from earth at Zeus's command, the first engineered human, and in Aeschylus's *Prometheus Bound* he forges the chains that fix Prometheus to the rock. Rand's title turns the Atlas myth into a parable of the productive class withdrawing its support from an ungrateful world. *BioShock* inverts the inversion. Its Atlas bears nothing: he is a voice without a body, a persona devised by a confidence man to harness the labour and grievance of others.

In the final confrontation Fontaine, saturated with ADAM, assumes a colossal, statuary form that recalls the Deco Titans. He is overthrown by the protagonist with the aid of the very children on whom the economy of ADAM has fed.

The Titanomachy, the overthrow of an older order of primal powers by a younger generation, is thus restaged, with its outcome left undetermined until the final choice.

5.2 Saturn: Devourer, Exile, Judge

The Titan whose myth organizes the game most completely is never named in it. Kronos, whom the Romans identified with Saturn, swallowed his children to prevent the prophesied usurpation of his rule, and was overthrown by the son who escaped him. Three further strands of the Saturnian myth bear directly on Rapture.

In Virgil's *Aeneid* (VIII.319–25), Saturn, fleeing the arms of Jupiter as an exile stripped of his kingdom, takes refuge in Italy, gathers a scattered people, gives them laws, and presides over a golden age; the region is called Latium, Virgil explains, because there he lay hidden. Ryan is this Saturn: the exile who flees a usurping power and founds, in hiding, a golden age that lasts roughly a decade before its collapse. In the Fourth *Eclogue*, the return of Saturn's reign is prophesied in the birth of a child under whom the age of iron will yield to gold. And in Hyginus's fable of Cura, Saturn is the judge who awards the living human to Care.

A single mythic identity thus contains the devouring father, the exiled founder of a hidden golden age, the reign whose return is heralded by a child, and the judge who assigns humanity to Care. Erwin Panofsky, Raymond Klibansky, and Fritz Saxl's *Saturn and Melancholy* (1964) traced how this contradictory deity became, in Renaissance thought, the patron of melancholy, genius, and ruin. Walter Benjamin, whom Susan Sontag (1980) placed under the sign of Saturn, made melancholy the affect of the allegorist who reads history in its fragments. The player, assembling the city's past from recordings scattered among its ruins, is cast in precisely that Saturnine role.

5.3 Oedipus and the Primal Father

The revelation that Jack is Ryan's son, and that he has killed his father, places the game in the line of Sophocles' *Oedipus Tyrannus*, with a decisive modification. Oedipus kills a stranger who is his father; Ryan knows his son and arranges to be killed by him. The tragic structure of unknowing is preserved on the side of the son and abolished on the side of the father, who converts the oracle into a script he directs.

The more exact model is Freud's *Totem and Taboo* (1913) and its speculative myth of the primal horde. A tyrannical father monopolizes power within the group until the sons combine to kill him. They consume his substance in a

totemic meal so as to appropriate his strength, and then, overcome by guilt, institute the prohibitions on which law and religion are founded. Rapture repeats the first two moments and fails to complete the third. The father is killed; his substance, ADAM, the city's patrimony, is consumed by sons who seek his power; Fontaine above all absorbs it in order to become the new father. What is missing is the guilt that converts murder into law. The question the endings answer is whether any law will be instituted at all, and of what kind.

5.4 Atlantis, Pandaemonium, Babel, Leviathan

Plato's *Timaeus* and *Critias* describe Atlantis, a maritime empire descended from Poseidon whose kings decline as the divine element in their nature is diluted by the mortal, until Zeus convenes the gods to pass judgment. The *Critias* breaks off at the very moment Zeus begins to speak: the verdict on the drowned utopia is never delivered. Rapture is an Atlantis built underwater by design rather than sunk by punishment, and its decline is likewise narrated as a degeneration of the human stock. The game, unlike Plato's fragment, delivers the verdict, and Chapter 8 argues that it does so in the voice of Saturn rather than of Zeus.

Milton's *Paradise Lost* (1667) supplies a still closer architectural model. In Book I the fallen angels raise Pandaemonium, their capital, from gold mined under the direction of Mammon, least upright of the spirits, whose gaze even in heaven was bent downward on its golden pavement. Its designer is Mulciber, known to the ancients as Vulcan, that is, Hephaestus. A capital of gold raised beneath the earth by Mammon and Hephaestus, a refuge for spirits who refused to serve: the description is an exact emblem of Rapture, whose founder's banner institutionalizes the angelic refusal and whose power plant bears Mulciber's Greek name. Ryan is a Miltonic Satan, magnificent in rhetoric and catastrophic in consequence, preferring sovereignty over a hell of his own making to service in a heaven of anyone else's.

Three biblical structures complete the topography. Babel, the tower raised to make a name and punished by the confusion of tongues (Genesis 11), is inverted in the lighthouse that descends, and its punishment returns in the fractured speech of the Splicers. Leviathan, the sea-monster of Job 41 that no human power can subdue, gave Hobbes the name for the sovereign state (1651). Ryan descends beneath the sea to escape Leviathan and finds himself in its belly, and his city's collapse reproduces the Hobbesian state of nature with clinical fidelity: a war of each against all, without industry, culture, or security. Finally, the eschatology from which the city takes its name, derived from the Vulgate's rendering of 1 Thessalonians 4:17, in which the faithful are caught up

into the air, is inverted twice. The elect are carried down rather than up, and the end of history they await turns out to be their own.

5.5 Descent, Revelation, and the Counterfeit Call

The protagonist's journey is a katabasis, a descent to the underworld of the kind undertaken by Odysseus, Aeneas, and Dante. Its most distinctive device, the audio diary, is a modern nekyia. In Book XI of the *Odyssey* the shades of the dead speak to Odysseus only after drinking blood, offering lament, testimony, and prophecy; in Rapture the dead speak only when the player recovers their recordings, and what they offer is confession.

The *Inferno* supplies the moral topography. Dante orders hell as a descending sequence of regions, each presided over by a characteristic sin, with fraud and treachery, sins that abuse the faculty of reason proper to humans, punished at its lowest depths. Rapture's districts are likewise presided over by characteristic vices: vanity in the clinic, aesthetic violence in the pleasure garden, proprietary pride in the power plant. Its final antagonist is, fittingly, the defrauder, the confidence man whose principal weapon is a counterfeit identity. Rand classed fraud alongside force as a primary violation of rights, so Fontaine embodies the one evil on which Dante and Rand agree.

The structure of revelation that governs the plot has a precise analogue in Gnostic literature. In the Hymn of the Pearl, preserved in the apocryphal*Acts of Thomas*, a prince is sent from his father's kingdom to Egypt to retrieve a pearl guarded by a serpent in the sea. He forgets his origin and mission until a letter from his parents awakens him; he then charms the serpent by pronouncing over it his father's name, seizes the pearl, and returns home. Hans Jonas's *The Gnostic Religion* (1958) identified this call from outside, which awakens the sleeper to his true identity, as the central Gnostic motif.

BioShock reproduces the structure and doubles it. The protagonist is sent into the sea with falsified memories; a voice from outside calls him and guides his steps; and the city's guarded places open to the name, that is, the genome, of his father. But the first call is counterfeit. Atlas's voice is the instrument of servitude rather than awakening, and the true call, Tenenbaum's, can awaken him only after the counterfeit has been exposed. Gnosis here is the discovery not of a divine origin but of a manufactured one.

Gnosis here is the discovery not of a divine origin but of a manufactured one.

The counterfeit call has further antecedents. Theseus escapes the labyrinth by Ariadne's thread; Rapture's equivalent, the navigational arrow that directs the player through the city, is held by the adversary, so that the thread out of the labyrinth leads only deeper in. Odysseus has himself bound to the mast so that he may hear the Sirens without obeying them, the model Jon Elster (1979) took as the paradigm of rational precommitment; Jack is bound without consent, so that he hears and obeys. Orwell's *Nineteen Eighty-Four* (1949) entertained the possibility that both the leader and the enemy of the state are fabrications. Fritz Lang's *Metropolis* (1927) supplied the political paradigm of the counterfeit revolutionary: a machine forged in the likeness of the workers' beloved prophet, who incites the lower city to a revolt that floods its own homes. Atlas is that false Maria, an invented leader whose insurrection serves its author; and Rapture, like the workers' city of *Metropolis*, drowns.

Table 1. Principal mythic correspondences

Source	Figure or structure	Correspondence in BioShock
Hesiod, *Theogony*; Aeschylus, *Prometheus Bound*	Atlas, Prometheus, Hephaestus; Kronos	The radio persona; Point Prometheus; the Hephaestus power plant; the father who consumes his heirs
Virgil, *Aeneid* VIII and *Eclogue* IV	Saturn hidden in Latium; the child of the returning golden age	Ryan's concealed golden age; the generations of the restorative ending
Hyginus, *Fabulae* 220	Cura, Jupiter, Tellus; Saturn as judge	Care, Command, Ownership; the player's computed verdict
Sophocles; Freud, *Totem and Taboo*	Unknowing patricide; the primal horde	Ryan's commanded death; ADAM consumed as totemic meal
Plato, *Timaeus* and *Critias*	Atlantis and its undelivered verdict	The drowned utopia and its narrative of degeneration
Milton, *Paradise Lost* I	Pandaemonium, Mammon, Mulciber	A city of gold beneath the sea; the district named Hephaestus
Genesis; Job; 1 Thessalonians	Adam and Eve; the curse of toil; Babel; Leviathan; the rapture	ADAM and EVE; the founding question; the descending tower; the city's name
Homer, *Odyssey* IX and XI	Nobody; the speaking shades	The silent protagonist; the audio diaries
Acts of Thomas	The Hymn of the Pearl	The father's genome as key; the doubled call
Homeric Hymn to Demeter	Descent and return of the daughter	Tenenbaum's arc; the ascent of the restorative ending

6 The Benthic Uncanny

BioShock *in the Genealogy of Horror*

6.1 The Sea as Exterior

The sea has long served the Western imagination as the figure of what lies outside the order of the polis: formless, abyssal, inimical to settlement. Jules Verne's *Twenty Thousand Leagues Under the Seas* (1869–70) transformed it into a refuge. Captain Nemo, who has renounced every terrestrial nation, finds beneath the surface a domain beyond the reach of despots, and furnishes his submarine with a library, a gallery of paintings, and an organ: an autarkic aesthete's state in the form of a vessel. Rapture is the *Nautilus* enlarged into a city.

Nemo's name, Latin for nobody, recalls the alias by which Odysseus deceives the Cyclops in Book IX of the *Odyssey*. The silent protagonist of *BioShock* is a nobody of the same kind: an empty position through which the player passes, bearing the most generic name in the language. The game eventually discloses that this nobody was also the agent of the crash that opens it, and the generic name acquires in retrospect the resonance of the word in which it is embedded: hijack.

6.2 From R'lyeh to Rapture

H. P. Lovecraft's "The Call of Cthulhu" (1928) places at the bottom of the sea a drowned city, R'lyeh, whose non-Euclidean architecture houses a sleeping entity whose awakening would annihilate the human sense of meaning. Rapture inverts R'lyeh term by term. Lovecraft's city is alien in origin and in-

different to humanity; Rapture is human in origin and intimately concerned with it. Lovecraft's horror is cosmic, the revelation of human insignificance before forces that do not notice us. Rapture's horror is economic, the revelation that humanity, given the means, will remake itself into the monsters Lovecraft located outside it. The god asleep beneath this sea is the self-made man, and what wakes is the Splicer.

The god asleep beneath this sea is the self-made man, and what wakes is the Splicer.

Two later Lovecraft narratives supply closer parallels.*At the Mountains of Madness* (1936) follows explorers through the ruins of a vanished civilization whose history they reconstruct from the carvings on its walls. This archaeological mode of narration is identical to what Henry Jenkins (2004) would theorize as environmental storytelling. The explorers discover that the civilization fell when the servitor species it had bioengineered for labour rebelled against its makers. Rapture's engineered servants, Protectors and Splicers alike, re-enact that rebellion.

"The Shadow over Innsmouth" (1936) describes a decaying fishing town whose prosperity was purchased through a compact with beings from the deep, gold exchanged for offerings, at the cost of its inhabitants' bodily transformation. Its narrator, an outside investigator, discovers in the final pages that he is himself descended from the town's lineage, and resolves to return to the sea. The structural correspondence is exact. Both narratives present an economy of riches drawn from the deep at the price of bodily metamorphosis and of the lives offered to sustain it, and an investigator from the surface who learns that he was never an outsider, that he was born of the place he came to explore.

The correspondence also marks a displacement. Lovecraft's horror of hybridity is inseparable from the racial anxieties documented throughout his work and correspondence.*BioShock* relocates the source of degeneration from descent to purchase, from blood to the market, and thereby converts a reactionary horror into a critique of the ideology of self-making that such anxieties often served.

6.3 The Modern Prometheus and the House of Pain

Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein* (1818) bears the subtitle*The Modern Prometheus*, and the conjunction names the game's laboratory. At Point Prometheus, life is manufactured, conditioned, and discarded. The Protectors are Frankenstein's

creature serialized, beings assembled from human material for a purpose not their own and denied any relation to their makers except use. Victor Frankenstein's crime, in Shelley's ethical design, lies less in the act of creation than in the refusal of responsibility that follows it. Tenenbaum's arc reverses Victor's, moving from creation to the assumption of responsibility for the created.

H. G. Wells's *The Island of Doctor Moreau* (1896) provides the political template: an isolated laboratory polity ruled by a scientist who remakes animals into quasi-human forms, holds them in order by a recited Law and a house of surgical pain, and watches them revert when his authority fails. Wells's *The Time Machine* (1895) had already imagined class stratification hardening into speciation, the leisured and the labouring diverging into distinct biological kinds. Rapture's genetic market accelerates that divergence from geological to commercial time: class becomes genotype at the speed of purchase.

6.4 The Uncanny Home

Freud's essay "The Uncanny" (1919) locates*das Unheimliche* in the return of the familiar in estranged form, the homely made unhomely. Rapture's horror is pervasively uncanny in this sense. Its iconography is the domestic and commercial imagery of mid-century America, the diner, the department store, the cheerful advertisement, the popular song, rendered in ruin and inhabited by figures whose speech still repeats the formulas of ordinary life.

Ernst Jentsch (1906), whose essay Freud took as his point of departure, had located the uncanny in doubt as to whether an apparently living being is truly animate, citing the automaton Olympia in E. T. A. Hoffmann's "The Sandman" (1816). Freud shifted the emphasis elsewhere, but the automaton remains the genre's emblem. Rapture is peopled by such ambiguities, from the mechanically bonded Protectors to the protagonist himself, who learns at the midpoint that he has been operating as an automaton all along.

Stephen King's *The Shining* (1977) offers a final comparator: an isolated luxury enclave in which the guests of a perpetual party persist as revenants and the present is gradually absorbed by the past. The New Year's Eve of 1958 is Rapture's perpetual party, its masked revellers still at their masquerade more than a year after the music stopped.

6.5 Lineage: System Shock 2 and the Treacherous Voice

The game's immediate generic ancestor is Irrational's *System Shock 2* (1999, with Looking Glass Studios), whose midpoint revelation that the trusted voice guiding the player was the antagonist in disguise*BioShock* deliberately repeats.

Across the two games a signature emerges: Levine's dramaturgy locates authority, and therefore the possibility of fraud, in the disembodied voice that speaks into the player's ear. That voice is the medium's own, the voice of the tutorial, the objective marker, the mission briefing. Both games turn the medium's habitual mode of address against the player who has learned to trust it, and *BioShock* adds to the formula the philosophical apparatus that makes the betrayal signify something beyond surprise.

7 The Player in the Box

Ludic Form as Philosophical Argument

7.1 The Magic Circle and Its Breach

Johan Huizinga's *Homo Ludens* (1938) described play as an activity bounded in space and time and governed by its own rules, within what Katie Salen and Eric Zimmerman's *Rules of Play* (2004) consolidated as the magic circle. Entry into the circle involves a tacit consent. The player agrees to pursue goals set by the game, by means the game permits, in exchange for the pleasure Janet Murray (1997) called agency: the gratification of acting meaningfully and seeing one's choices take effect. This consent is the condition of play, and it is ordinarily invisible.

BioShock's midpoint revelation makes it visible. Throughout the first half the player has followed instructions prefaced by the trigger phrase without remarking it, because following instructions is what players do. When Ryan exposes the conditioning of the protagonist, he exposes in the same gesture the habitual docility of the player. The breach of the circle consists in the discovery that consent to play was indistinguishable, at the level of observable behaviour, from conditioned obedience.

7.2 Procedural Rhetoric and the Behaviorist Machine

Ian Bogost's *Persuasive Games* (2007) proposed that games argue through procedural rhetoric, the authoring of arguments through rule-based processes rather than speech or image. The concept clarifies what the game's rules argue independently of its script. Its economy rewards acquisition, and its vending

machines dispense rewards on schedules. Its progression system invites the player to invest in the protagonist's body exactly as Rapture's citizens invested in theirs. Its research camera rewards the photographing of enemies with combat bonuses, reprising Cohen's aesthetic of the photographed body in the register of mechanics. At the level of rule the game is an operant chamber, and the player is its subject. Alexander Galloway's description of games as allegories of control (2006) finds here an unusually literal instance.

The point can be generalized, and the generalization is the strongest claim of this chapter. A digital game, as a computational system, can register only behaviour: inputs, states, and outcomes. It has no access to the maxims under which a player acts, the reasons for a choice, or the dispositions it expresses. In Kant's terms it can record the legality of an act but never its morality, since moral worth resides in the maxim from which an act is done rather than in its outward conformity to duty (*Groundwork*, 1785). The game is therefore structurally behaviorist, not as a matter of design philosophy but as a condition of its medium. *BioShock* is the most prominent early work in its medium to make this structural behaviorism the explicit content of its narrative. It tells a story about the impossibility of distinguishing freedom from conditioning by observing behaviour, in a medium that can observe nothing else.

7.3 Dissonance as Mimesis

Hocking's diagnosis identified a contradiction between the game's ludic contract, which invites the player to pursue self-interest by extracting ADAM, and its narrative contract, which compels the player to serve Atlas without the possibility of refusal; he concluded that the game undermined its own argument. The reading proposed here inverts the evaluation. The dissonance between what the player is told and what the player is made to do is the formal correlate of the dissonance between the Objectivist subject's self-description and its actual condition. Rapture's citizens believed themselves sovereign choosers while advertising, addiction, and price shaped their conduct; the player believes himself a free agent while reward schedules and objective markers shape his.

Slavoj Žižek (1989), reworking Peter Sloterdijk's diagnosis of cynical reason (1983), proposed that ideology in late modernity no longer depends on false belief. Subjects know very well what they are doing and do it nonetheless, so that ideology resides in practice rather than in consciousness. The game's dissonance is a mimesis of ideology in exactly this sense. It does not misrepresent its thesis; it makes the player perform the gap between belief and practice that the thesis describes.

7.4 The Choice Under Surveillance

The choice between lethal extraction and restorative release has been criticized, notably by Miguel Sicart (*The Ethics of Computer Games*, 2009; *Beyond Choices*, 2013), as a reduction of ethics to a binary and of consequences to a tally. Two further features deserve emphasis. First, the economy nearly equalizes the two paths. Release yields roughly half the immediate ADAM of extraction, but Tenenbaum compensates the rescuer with periodic gifts that close most of the gap. Virtue is rewarded, and in being rewarded it is converted back into prudence: the system cannot represent disinterested goodness, because its only medium of representation is reward.

Second, the choice is observed. In Book II of Plato's *Republic*, Glaucon tells of Gyges, who finds a ring that renders him invisible and uses it to commit injustice with impunity, and asks whether anyone would remain just if freed from observation.*BioShock* grants the player a Gyges-like power, a tonic that renders the protagonist invisible while he stands still, and a world without witnesses. It does not grant invisibility from the system, which records every choice and computes from their aggregate the ending the player will receive. The player's morality is exercised under a panoptic gaze in Foucault's sense (*Discipline and Punish*, 1975): not the gaze of a person but of an apparatus whose verdict is deferred and certain. The experiment of the ring is never actually performed, because the machine is always watching.

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7.5 The Ludic Undead and the Aporia of Emancipation

The Vita-Chamber, which reconstitutes the protagonist after every death, removes finitude from the game world, converting death into an interruption rather than an end. The protagonist is a ludic undead, perpetually reanimated to continue the tasks set for him. Finitude, Chapter 8 will argue, is the condition of the game's only redemptive resolution.

The second structure is the aporia that follows the revelation. After Tenenbaum deprograms the protagonist, the game continues exactly as before: a voice in the ear issues instructions, the arrow points the way, and the player follows. Many players and critics have experienced this as anticlimax, a failure to deliver the freedom the revelation seemed to promise. It is better understood

as the game's most honest moment. A behaviorist machine cannot represent emancipation as a difference in behaviour, because the conduct of a freely cooperating agent and of a conditioned one are, from the machine's standpoint, identical. The difference between obeying Atlas and following Tenenbaum lies wholly in the reasons for which the player acts, and reasons are precisely what the game cannot see.

Freedom within the circle can only be the substitution of one voice for another; freedom from the circle can only be its end. *BioShock* accordingly locates its sole representation of a fully free act outside play altogether, in the non-interactive sequence that closes the restorative ending.

7.6 The Two Heteronomies

Emmanuel Levinas (*Totality and Infinity*, 1961) argued that ethics begins not in the autonomy of a self-legislating will but in the encounter with the face of the other, whose vulnerability issues a command that precedes and founds the subject's freedom. Levinasian ethics is therefore a heteronomy, but of a specific kind. The command of the face does not bypass the subject's will, as a password bypasses a lock; it summons the subject into responsibility.

The game stages both heteronomies with exactness. The trigger phrase is mechanical heteronomy, a command that reaches the body without passing through the person. The choice sequence, framed in close-up on the child's face, is ethical heteronomy, a command that can be refused and that constitutes the one who answers it. Between them, Ryan's autonomy, the will that legislates for itself and owes nothing, appears as an illusion sustained only by ignoring both. The resolution of the game depends on which heteronomy the player answers.

Saturn's Verdict

Ownership, Command, and Care

8.1 The Trial

BioShock adjudicates a dispute over title to the human being among three claimants whose arguments correspond to the three parties in Hyginus's fable. Ryan pleads as Tellus: the human belongs to the one whose substance it is. His is the claim of property in one's own person, extended to the body as matter one may improve, sell, or destroy; its proof is *abusus*, and its logic ends in the annihilation of what it owns. Fontaine pleads as Jupiter: the human belongs to the one who animates it, who supplies the spirit that moves the clay. His is the claim of command, the word that sets the body in motion; its instrument is conditioning, and its logic ends in a being that moves without willing.

Tenenbaum pleads as Cura: the human belongs, for as long as it lives, to the one who first shaped it with attention and who now attends to it. Hers is the claim of care. Her own history, in which she shaped the children's condition before undertaking to undo it, makes her the fable's Cura in the most literal sense: the one who first worked the clay, and who must answer for what she made.

Ownership and Command are not opposites but complementary halves of a single disposition toward the human as object: on the one hand material to be disposed of, on the other an instrument to be directed. Rapture is the polity in which they meet. Ryan's ideology supplied the matter and Fontaine's methods the motion. The Splicer, an owned body moved by commanded appetite, is their joint product; so, in a more refined form, is Jack.

Table 2. The three claimants

Claim	Party in Hyginus	Advocate in BioShock	Instrument	Terminal logic
Ownership	Tellus (Earth): the body	Andrew Ryan	Property in the person; *abusus*	Annihilation of what is owned
Command	Jupiter: the spirit	Frank Fontaine, with Suchong	Conditioning; the trigger phrase	A body that moves without willing
Care	Cura: the living whole	Brigid Tenenbaum, finally Jack	Attention, protection, release	A finite life lived among others

8.2 Abyssal Autarky Revisited

The pressure-hull image introduced in Chapter 1 can now be specified. Abyssal autarky is the attempt to secure Earth's claim, the self as sovereign property, by excluding everything that would qualify it: dependence, obligation, the unchosen relation, the claim of the other. The sea is the figure of that excluded exterior. But the excluded returns through every seam, and returns as precisely what the autarkic subject denied. It returns as parasitic dependence, in the economy of ADAM; as command, in the conditioning that the market's incentives prefigure and Fontaine's science perfects; and as the unchosen relation of kinship, in the son whose existence Ryan never acknowledged and whose hands carry out his death.

Goethe's Faust, blinded by the figure of Care whom he refuses to acknowledge, mistakes the sound of his own grave being dug for the building of his free polity. Ryan's blindness is of the same kind. What he refused, under the names of parasitism and altruism, was Care; and Care, unacknowledged, returned as the blindness through which his city dug its grave.

8.3 Two Saturns

The player, whose choices the game aggregates into a verdict, occupies the seat of Saturn, and the myth's double identity defines the alternatives. One Saturn is Kronos the devourer, who consumes his children to secure his power against succession. The extraction choice repeats his gesture: the substance of the child is consumed to augment the strength of the consumer. The ending that follows from a pattern of extraction completes the Kronian logic on a planetary scale. The protagonist seizes the city and turns its forces outward, capturing a submarine armed with nuclear missiles; the right to destroy, which Ryan exercised over a forest and a city, is extended to the world. This is Ryan's ethic realized

without remainder: Earth's claim, pursued to its limit, is the claim to dispose of everything.

The other Saturn is the judge of Hyginus's fable, who awards the living human to Care. The restorative ending enacts this judgment. Tenenbaum's narration describes the children returned to the surface and living out ordinary lives, schooling, marriage, and families of their own, and closes on the protagonist, aged, at the end of his life, attended by those he saved. Three features of the sequence realize the fable's verdict with remarkable exactness.

First, the protagonist dies. The Vita-Chamber had held him in ludic undeath, perpetually reanimated for the purposes of those who commanded him; the restorative ending returns him to mortality. In the fable, Care's possession is bounded by death, at which body and spirit revert to their sources. Finitude is not the defeat of Care's claim but its condition: only a mortal being can be cared for, because only a mortal being can be lost. *Being and Time* binds care and being-toward-death together as co-original structures of human existence; the game binds them together as narrative fact.

Second, the relation in which the protagonist ends is elective and non-proprietary. He is a father to the children neither by blood nor by purchase, but by adoption. The Oedipal and Kronian sequences that organize the rest of the game, fathers consuming children, sons killing fathers, sons becoming fathers who consume, are not resolved but exited. The protagonist does not inherit Ryan's city, as the sons of Freud's myth inherit the father's power; he leaves it. The primal murder is followed not by a new sovereign but by a household, and the law instituted in place of the father's law is the law of care.

Third, the sequence cannot be played. The only fully free act in *BioShock*, the decision to live a life of care outside every system of command, is represented as spectacle, not interaction. This is not, as it has sometimes been taken to be, a failure of nerve. It is the logical consequence of the argument of Chapter 7. A behaviorist machine can depict care but cannot instantiate it, because care, unlike obedience, does not consist in a sequence of behaviours that a system could record. The game's last word on its own medium is that freedom begins where play ends.

Freedom begins where play ends.

8.4 Et in Arcadia Ego

The Arcadia district, the poisoned forest at the city's centre, condenses the argument in a single image. Erwin Panofsky's essay on Poussin and the elegiac tradition (1936; revised 1955) showed that the inscription*Et in Arcadia ego*, in its original sense, is spoken by Death: even in Arcadia, I am present. Later readings that heard in it an elegiac sigh, I too once dwelt in Arcadia, softened a memento mori into nostalgia.

Rapture's Arcadia preserves the harsher sense. It is a pastoral enclave engineered as property, metered at its gates, and poisoned by its owner: a garden in which death is present not as the natural limit of life but as the exercise of a property right. The restorative ending returns death to its other meaning, the natural limit of a life lived, met in old age within the circle of care. Between the two Arcadias lies the whole distance between Earth's claim and Care's, between death as *abusus* and death as finitude.

Virgil's Fourth *Eclogue*, finally, prophesied the return of Saturn's reign in the birth of a child. In the restorative ending, the golden age that Ryan, the exiled Saturn, sought to found in hiding beneath the sea is not restored in Rapture. It is dispersed into ordinary lives on the surface, in children who grow up and have children of their own. Saturn's age returns not as a city but as a generation.

8.5 Tenenbaum as Demeter

The mythic figure presiding over this resolution is Demeter, whose daughter descends to the underworld and whose grief withholds the earth's fertility until the gods negotiate the daughter's return. The *Homeric Hymn to Demeter*, foundational text of the Eleusinian Mysteries, is a narrative of descent and anodos, return to the upper world, and of a mother whose refusal to accept loss compels a cosmic renegotiation. Tenenbaum's arc follows Demeter's: grief transformed into agency, agency directed toward the return of the daughters from below. The sequel would later name Rapture's political prison Persephone, as if acknowledging the structure. Eleusis promised its initiates a better lot after death; the restorative ending promises nothing beyond the dignity of an ordinary mortality, and therein lies its quiet radicalism.

8.6 Objections

Three objections must be met. The first holds that the resolution is sentimental, and that elevating care over ownership and command repeats the evasive conclusion of Lang's *Metropolis*. There, a heart mediating between head and hands

reconciles capital and labour without altering their relation, a resolution Siegfried Kracauer (*From Caligari to Hitler*, 1947) read as an alibi for domination. The distinction is decisive. Lang's heart mediates and thereby preserves the hierarchy it softens;*BioShock*'s care renounces sovereignty altogether. The protagonist does not reconcile Rapture's factions; he abandons the city and its claims.

The second objection holds that the binary morality system trivializes the ethics it stages, and that an ending computed from a tally cannot bear the philosophical weight assigned to it here. The objection is right about the system and wrong about its significance. The tally is the behaviorist machine's best approximation of judgment, and the game's argument depends on the visible inadequacy of that approximation. The disparity between the mechanical computation and the ethical content it purports to measure is itself part of what the game shows.

The third objection holds that the reading is anachronistic, attributing to a commercial artifact intentions its makers did not hold. The thesis claims no authorial intention beyond what is documented: Levine's public acknowledgement of Rand and Orwell among his sources, and the evident deliberation of the game's mythological nomenclature. Its claim concerns the coherence of the artifact, not the biography of its authors. On Claude Lévi-Strauss's account in *The Raw and the Cooked* (1964), myths operate in human minds without their awareness; the structures traced here are present in the work whether or not they were consciously designed.

Coda

Afterlives, Limits, and Further Research

The sequels extend the argument in revealing directions.*BioShock 2* (2K Marin, 2010) sets against Ryan's individualism the collectivism of Sophia Lamb, whose utilitarian project of dissolving the self into a single communal organism reproduces, from the opposite pole, the same instrumentalization of the child. Its protagonist is a Protector, and its moral system weighs the duties of a father. The sequel thereby confirms that the original's critique was never directed at individualism alone, but at any order that claims title to persons, whether in the name of the self or of the collective.

BioShock Infinite (2013) generalizes the structure across a multiverse of constants and variables, so that recurrence itself becomes the theme: there is always a city, always a founder, always a voice in the ear. Nietzsche's eternal return, proposed as the supreme test of affirmation, becomes in Levine's later work a cage. The *Burial at Sea* episodes (2013–14) close the circle by returning to Rapture before its fall.

The original's afterlife has not been confined to fiction. In 2008, the year after its release, the Seasteading Institute was founded to promote autonomous ocean communities beyond the jurisdiction of existing states. It renewed a lineage that includes the Principality of Sealand (1967) and the short-lived Republic of Minerva (1972), a libertarian micronation on a Pacific reef annexed by Tonga within months of its declaration. Critics of such projects have invoked Rapture with regularity. The invocation is apt in a sense they rarely specify: abyssal autarky is not a fictional conceit but a recurring political fantasy, and its recurrence is what the game's Saturnian structure predicts.

The limits of the present reading should be stated. It privileges the restorative ending as the locus of the argument, though the extraction ending is equally canonical within the fiction. It reads the sequels selectively. It sets aside questions of ethnic and gendered representation, including the characterization of Suchong, that deserve independent treatment. And it does not engage the empirical literature on how players actually make the game's central choice, which would test the claim that its mechanics function as an operant chamber.

Each limit marks a direction for further research. One is a comparative study of moral-choice architectures across the decade that followed*BioShock*. Another is an inquiry into the gendering of care in a game whose rescued children and rescuing scientist are female while its owners and commanders are male. A third is a fuller account of the medium's structural behaviorism, which this thesis has asserted more than it has demonstrated.

What the game demonstrates, finally, is that the question it inherits from Rand, whether a person belongs to herself, is incomplete. Between the owner who claims the body and the commander who claims the will, *BioShock* discovers a third claimant whose title neither excludes nor coerces, and whose authority lasts exactly as long as the life it attends. It cannot let its player exercise that claim. It can only end, and in ending, show what lies outside the box.



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BioShock | Ken Levine | Irrational Games | Rapture | Objectivism | Ayn Rand | B. F. Skinner | behaviorism | operant conditioning | abyssal autarky | parasitic sovereignty | Michel Serres | biopolitics | human capital | liberal eugenics | interpellation | societies of control | informed consent | ludonarrative dissonance | procedural rhetoric | magic circle | moral choice systems | Saturn | Kronos | Cura fable | ethics of care | Heidegger | Levinas | Titanomachy | Atlantis | Pandaemonium | Faust | Gnosticism | katabasis | weird fiction | Lovecraft | the uncanny | Frankenstein | dystopian fiction | philosophy of games

